

EUREKA!

IDEAS DON'T COME AT YOUR BECK AND CALL. THEY ARE ELUSIVE THINGS, TO BE NURTURED AND INCUBATED AS THEY COME, SO MAKE SURE YOU WRITE DOWN THAT INSANE IDEA YOU JUST HAD. IT MIGHT JUST MAKE YOU A MILLIONAIRE.

By Anshumala Balu

A spontaneous idea can hit you like a bolt from the blue. It can come to you anywhere, any time – while hiking, napping, socialising and indeed, while bathing. Fortunately, most people who stumble upon an idea resist the urge to run out into the street yelling “Eureka!”. However, there’s a common trait among most of these unbidden startup ideas, and that is how audacious, stupid or crazy they initially sound. While executing these in the Big Bad World is a whole different ball game, hope presents itself in the form of potential.

Inspiration is everywhere! All you have to do is keep your eyes peeled. Like these guys did.

THE CALCULATOR

In 1642, French prodigy Blaise Pascal designed the first counting machine at the age of 18. The contraption, a device that

“My ideas usually come not at my desk writing, but in the midst of living.”

– ANAIS NIN

could perform all four arithmetic operations without relying on human intelligence, was created to help out his father, who happened to be a tax collector. Called the ‘Pascaline’, the machine relied on geared wheels and could add and subtract two numbers directly as well as multiply and divide by repetition. It was basically an early form of the now standard calculator. He made



Oh, Archimedes

somewhere between 20 to 50 of them, however nobody was interested in them at the time. It was only 300 years later that the calculator became all the rage and he was established as one of the two early inventors of the mechanical calculator – the other being Wilhelm Schickard.

THE POPSICLE

One cold evening in 1905, 11-year-old Frank Epperson left a mixture of powdered drink mix and water with the stirring stick in a cup on the porch of his house. Given the frigid temperatures in San Francisco at that time of year, he woke up to find a frozen treat on a stick. Excited by his invention, he continued to make these ice pops for friends. It was only a matter of time before he realised their commercial viability. They were a



Pascaline – the first calculator

huge hit. He named the accidental invention ‘Epsicle’ after himself. Eventually, when his kids started calling them “Pop’s ‘sicles”, Epperson officially changed the name to ‘Popsicle’ in 1923.

VELCRO

In 1941, Swiss engineer George de Mestral and his dog went for a nature hike, after which the man and his best friend returned covered in burrs (the seed sacs plants use to pollinate). Being an engineer, de Mestral grabbed a microscope and the rest is history. He saw the small hooks vigorously clinging on to the tiny loops in the fabric of his pants. We hope he remembered to brush his dog after. His idea for a hook-and-loop fastener was initially met with condescending scepticism by the European fabric industry, but the inventor “stuck” by his decision. It took another 14 years to patent the “zipperless zipper”, and in 1999, de Mestral was inducted into the USA’s National Inventors Hall of Fame for being the founding father of a multi-million dollar industry. The word “velcro” is derived from the French words “velour” (velvet) and “crochet” (hooks). So essentially, Velcro just means “hooked velvet”.

LAMBORGHINI

Ferruccio Lamborghini was a farmer turned entrepreneur, who originally owned a tractor company and was already one of the wealthiest men in Italy at the time. Being a car lover, he owned many sports cars including the Ferrari 250 GT. He noticed that the clutch in his car was the same one he had put in his tractors. Over time, he grew tired of recurring problems with the car’s clutch and decided to approach Ferrari himself.